

CHAPTER 5

Aligning Energy Grids, Clouds and Public Values in Sweden

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Introduction

In the spring of 2023, the international military producer Nammo made the headlines in international press with the announcement that the company was unable to expand its ammunition production factory in Norway because of a TikTok data centre that had claimed all the available grid transmission capacity in the region of Hamar (Yerushalmy, 2023). Nammo's expansion was intended to help alleviate ammunition shortages that had arisen in relation to the European military support for Ukraine in its ongoing resistance of the Russian invasion. However, the TikTok data centre had highjacked all the grid capacity in the region and prevented the upscaling of ammunition production. The news was remarkable but not unique. A year earlier, housing construction in West London was halted as the local grid ran out of capacity due to a concentration of data centres in the area (Hammond & Morris, 2022). In Sweden, in 2021, Microsoft inaugurated, with great fanfare, a data centre in the Skåne province amidst

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the worst capacity deficit in the power grid in the history of the region; this pushed the major local industrial bakery, a plastic manufacturer, and other industries to look to establishing their production facilities elsewhere (Libertson et al., 2021). Around the same time, in the region of Mälardalen in Sweden, Amazon Web Services (AWS) established three data centres. The then CEO of the regional electricity grid warned already in 2019 that no other large electricity-intense industries would be able to connect to the grid thereafter in this region (Selin, 2018).

Contemporary debates regarding the environmental sustainability of computing and artificial intelligence (AI) systems have specified energy as a central problem. The magnitude of electricity consumed by digital infrastructure and, particularly, by data centres has been discussed at length (Cubitt, 2017; Ensmenger, 2018; Marks, 2024; Maxwell & Miller, 2012; Ortar et al., 2023). The sources of energy for computing are commonly associated today with increases in carbon emissions, leading to calls for greater environmental accountability of the digital tech sector regarding its contribution to climate change (Brevini, 2022; Dovbysh et al., 2025; Kuntsman & Rattle, 2019). Accounting for the carbon emissions of computing is in itself a contested knowledge practice (Pasek et al., 2023), which nevertheless continues to animate computer engineers' efforts to calculate, ever more precisely, the carbon emissions of AI systems, such as model training and inference (Luccioni et al., 2023).

Amidst these debates, the examples above further highlight how routine technical operations of connecting computers in data centres to power grids are not only operations that involve carbon and the environment but are also social operations that affect the distribution of access to energy infrastructure. In this chapter, I argue that whether digital infrastructures are sustainable cannot be seen as a singular expression of their link to a chemical such as carbon but is also a result of how infrastructure operations promote or compromise public values of access.[1] As new EU policies promote the development of AI factories across Europe, the question regarding equal and fair access to electricity for citizens and industries is only going to gain greater importance. In this context, it is crucial to ask: how are the compromised values of shared access to basic infrastructure, such as energy grids, imagined to be restored or addressed?

[1] I draw on van Dijck et al.'s (2018) discussion of public values as values that contribute to the common good, and the recognition that both public values and the common good are performative, historically and culturally shaped, and at stake in democratic societies.

And, what are the conditions that contribute to creating these issues to begin with? After all, software designated as "AI" has existed for decades (Suchman, 1987) and so has computing and digital infrastructure. Then, what is the problem today?

In this chapter, I propose infrastructural misalignment as a lens to engage with these questions. With this perspective, I seek to recast critique regarding the sustainability of digital infrastructure and its relationship with energy in a new direction by emphasising the importance of considering how public values are compromised or upheld across entangled infrastructure that supports the expansion of AI systems. This perspective contributes to expanding scholarly discussions on the relationship among energy, sustainability, and digital infrastructure (Bresnihan & Brodie, 2023; Pasek et al., 2023; Velkova, 2021), as well as to the understanding about the relationship between public values and algorithmic systems (Lehtiniemi, 2024; Ruckenstein & Turunen, 2019; Zakharova et al., 2024).

Misaligned Infrastructures

Following a classic anthropological definition, infrastructure can be defined as things and relationships that enable the movement of other things through forms of governance that appear detached from formal institutions (Larkin, 2013). Scholarship on infrastructure has produced a large body of research concerned with questions of citizenship, knowledge, power, and temporality in relation to distinct "forms" of infrastructure: networks of roads and railways, energy, the internet, and audio-visual and mobile media. More recently, data centres have emerged as a distinct subset of digital infrastructure that has catalysed scholarly analyses of the entanglements among data processing, digitalisation, energy, and the environment (Edwards et al., 2024).

Most scholarly discussions on infrastructure have tended to compartmentalise infrastructure and base analyses on distinct industrial segments. For example, scholars analyse space infrastructure, urban infrastructure, science infrastructure, information infrastructure, energy systems, and data centres with their distinct logics and politics, but seldom engage with their multiple interrelations and how the differences among systems

are evened out and smoothened.[2] Running against this tendency, science and technology studies scholar Janet Vertesi (2014) emphasises how any infrastructure always exists as an entanglement of multiple infrastructures that messily overlap with each other. For example, power grid infrastructures co-exist and support the operations of science infrastructure, transport networks, digital computing, and many more systems. Each such infrastructure system has its own logic that supports specific rationalities, commodities, and services, often existing in misalignment with other systems. There can be numerous sources of this misalignment: different professional work practices, differing regulations and markets, varied temporalities and spatialities, drift and brokenness, as well as distinct value orientations. From such a perspective, infrastructure operations are always an ongoing accomplishment achieved through the alignment of logics, values, and other elements across profoundly heterogeneous systems.

Misalignment demands efforts by different actors to produce "fleeting moments of alignment suited to particular tasks with materials ready-to-hand" (Vertesi, 2014, p. 268) across entangled infrastructures. Using examples from the work of scientists and engineers on a robot space mission, Vertesi shows how participants of the mission align and smoothen non-aligned standards, professional identities, cultural norms, and digital technologies for communication on an everyday basis, which is achieved through mundane rituals such as phone calls, individual adjustments, or by technical means to produce coherence. Crucially, alignments are not always successful. Vertesi shows how a simple mismatch between Mac and PC infrastructural systems can leave scientists powerless, thus changing the course of expensive space mission operations. Misalignment further calls for repairs and realignments that become domains of power negotiations, as they prompt questions such as what and whose work is to be aligned, and to what end?

Digital infrastructures are no exception. They emerge in misalignment with other entangled systems. For example, certain data centre operators attempt to promote the value of data security through their infrastructures by siting computers in places that are already associated with security, such as bomb shelters and bunkers (Taylor, 2021). However, the logics that govern bomb shelters are different from those that govern data centres. Public authorities that administer the use of these spaces have to negotiate

[2] Although, of course, this topic has been addressed extensively in STS with a focus on standards, see, for example, Star and Bowker (2004).

the values of preparedness and citizen protection in case of emergencies in addition to the possibilities of commodifying such spaces, as they are available but have often been in a state of disuse for a long time (Velkova, 2023). The differing value orientations of civic defence and data centre infrastructure produces infrastructure misalignments that require public administrations to take decisions regarding what to prioritise and when as well as how to align their differing values by allowing or disallowing specific infrastructural connections.

In similar vein, multinational companies place data centres in the Nordic countries from where they can uphold the values of environmental care simply by connecting data centres to already existing infrastructure that apparently promotes these values, such as electricity grids powered by renewable electricity or district heat systems (Salling & Winthereik, 2025). In these cases, power grid providers and regional administrations have to negotiate the different spatial logics of digital and energy infrastructure, such as the emergent new geographies of intermittent renewable energy supply versus the location demands of data centres; differing temporal logics, such as the long-term planning of energy systems versus the quick pace of development of the tech sector and obsolescence of digital technologies and infrastructures (Chun, 2017; Velkova, 2019); and the different economies of energy and data.

From this perspective, data centres assume an infrastructural role for the digital economies of data and AI systems through the constant alignment of different infrastructure logics and the differing values that they seek to promote (see also Bojzcuk in this volume). But what are these values? In the next section, I suggest that infrastructural misalignments, and the resulting societal and environmental harms from them, are not an intrinsic quality of data centres but a result of a particular cultural form (Williams, 1974) of organising digital computing in the present that promotes the value of hyper-scalability, which demands the constant upscaling of entangled infrastructures to accommodate this form but fails to do so.

Hyper-Scalable Computing Meets Non-Scalable Power Grids

Contemporary AI services require computing power and, often, a substantial amount of it. This power is needed to process the data that is fed into different models, to train algorithms, and to generate

estimates regarding the relevance of calculated results. Today, tech multinationals offer computing power for such operations through "cloud computing" services. Cloud computing is a contemporary form of organising computing infrastructure in which organisations aggregate computers in data centres, virtualise and group computers as logical entities, and package them as services available for rent on demand (Hu, 2015). Narayan (2022) describes how cloud computing is a form of outsourcing that enables new forms of corporate organisation of digital service provision and labour premised upon a cultural logic of "hyper-scalability" of computing and infrastructural resources. Hyper-scalable computing, as Narayan defines it, promises companies and organisations the ability to scale by providing digital services without the upfront costs of owning or managing infrastructure. Hyper-scalability makes computing appear virtually limitless and, apparently, also costless (Powell, 2024). A radical shift from earlier forms of organising computing infrastructure, cloud computing makes computational resources available "on the tap" (Narayan, 2022).

Today, AWS, Microsoft, and Google are the largest providers of such services in Europe (Narayan, 2022). These companies also promote hyper-scalable cloud infrastructure as a resource for AI development. For example, AWS offers SageModel Training, a package of algorithms, computing resources, models, and training datasets, including synthetic data modelling. Microsoft offers an entire catalogue of language and vision models as part of a package of "AI Solutions" branded under the slogan "Build and Scale Exceptional Generative AI Systems" (Microsoft, 2025, para1). On their cloud computing website, Microsoft Azure is advertised with the following promise: "Amplify human ingenuity. Dream big and create breakthroughs with the latest AI solutions. Pay as you go or try Azure free for up to 30 days. There's no upfront commitment—cancel anytime" (Microsoft, 2025, Azure AI Solutions).

These services come with a choice of locations that prospective customers can select from, where certain locations offer the attributes of "sustainability" to computing resources depending on where in the world the data centres on which these services run are located. For example, Microsoft and AWS both promote their Swedish-based data centres as offering sustainable computing and AI by associations with the energy infrastructure in Sweden, which is powered by renewable energy. Hyper-scalability promises that computing resources are available to anyone at any cost and pressurises companies to develop data centres. However,

when data centres scale, energy and other societal infrastructure, such as water and energy grids, are simply unable to grow as fast, thus resulting in an infrastructure misalignment that manifests through compromising the value of equal access to basic infrastructure services.

For example, on 16 November 2021, during the COVID-19 pandemic, Microsoft announced the inauguration of a new cloud computing region that the company had produced for current and prospective users of Microsoft Azure and Microsoft 365 (Microsoft, 2021). The region consisted of three data centres that Microsoft built in three towns located far from each other—Staffanstorp, Gävle, and Sandviken—in Sweden. The centres offered initially scalable cloud services, security, local data storage (which subsequently included computers for AI-labelled services), and sustainability to prospective users.

In its compulsory inaugural press release, Microsoft emphasised that these data centres were the company's most advanced and sustainably designed ones, as they were zero waste, ran on backup power with environmentally certified diesel and 100 % renewable energy, and utilised a software that would measure the use of renewable electricity on an hourly basis. Microsoft added a commitment to use less water and produce less waste in the future in Sweden (Microsoft, 2021).

Microsoft's announcement for a new data centre and virtual cloud region came at the same time as Skåne—the Swedish region where one of these three data centres was located—experienced the worst shortage of transmission capacity in the region (Skånes effektkommission NET, 2025). In 2020, no new connections to the power grid in Skåne could be established and no existing ones could be upgraded; all the while, the electricity-intense Microsoft data centre had managed to secure connections ahead of the shortages—thus contributing to these shortages—and was preparing to open its data centre. The deficit in transmission capacity was a limitation for numerous projects in the region. Municipal plans to develop train connections in the region and citizen projects to generate solar power through their own photovoltaics (PV) installations were affected. Local companies and industries announced plans to move elsewhere (Libertson et al., 2021). The capacity deficit also resulted in queues for power grid connections that could extend to years depending on how large a connection a client would request.

Grid operators in Sweden are obliged to connect anyone who wants a connection to the grid within a two-year period or less (Swedish Energy Markets Inspectorate, 2021). When Microsoft requested a connection

to the local power grid, the operator E.ON could not reject it as long as there were available capacities at the time of request, irrespective of whether granting connection would lead to capacity deficits and delays in connections for other industries. The mandate to connect anyone produces universal access to electricity as a public value, a value historically related to the development of a welfare state in Sweden. Developments such as those with the Microsoft data centre put pressure on this value not only locally but also nationally in many major towns in Sweden which, coincidentally, also host many data centres. For example, in the region of Stockholm, a data centre industrial park called "Stockholm Data Parks", established by the city of Stockholm, energy companies, and a fibre optic infrastructure provider has come to a standstill. The park is branded as "sustainable" and low carbon because it would heat the town with excess heat from data centres; however, no data centres can be built there at present because data centres in other areas of the town, together with electrifying industries and other large electricity producers, have claimed such a large volume of electricity that there are no significant capacities available in the capital. Therefore, the data centres that are part of Stockholm Data Parks are in queue until 2030, when more grid capacity is expected to become available (Stockholm City, 2025).

Deficits in grid capacity reflect a misalignment in the temporalities of scaling between data and energy infrastructure, thus compromising the public value of universal and equal access to electricity in Sweden. These issues come on top of already existing internal misalignments within the energy system—for example, between the locations where electricity is generated and where it is consumed, thus creating imbalances and the prospect of power cuts. They also put pressure on renewables that have to be produced in greater quantities to make data centres "sustainable", thus generating even further misalignments.[3]

[3] For example, the current demand for computing power for AI systems has sparked conversations regarding the production of more nuclear power and building modular nuclear reactors to be colocated with data centers (Stover, 2024), which raise societal conflicts regarding nuclear waste handling, siting, and public health.

Realignments: Upscaling Electricity Grids

The situation of the capacity deficit in Skåne triggered massive local and national efforts to produce more capacity in the power grid. The regional grid operator E.ON upgraded several transformers, entered into a new contract with a transmission line called Baltic Cable between Sweden and Germany, installed a new system to load balance transmission, and—from 2021 onwards—promoted algorithmic solutions that enticed people to shift their practices of cooking or charging cars, their use of electricity in general to free grid capacities at times when those were most needed from the perspective of the power grid (E.ON, 2025). These measures made available 1 TW of power, the equivalent of all Malmö's energy demand on a cold day. Despite its magnitude, politicians and regional grid operators deemed the new capacity insufficient in light of expected future demand by data centres, municipal electrification projects, and electrifying industries (Skånes effektkommission NET, 2025). They anticipated even higher demand and braced themselves for the need to produce even more power.

Further, the regional and municipal administrations as well as grid operator E.ON anticipated a historical increase in demand for electricity that called for what they saw as a historical upscaling of grids. Projects were launched to forecast future capacity needs (Effektprognoser, 2025). A commission on expanding the grid in Skåne was initiated in 2024; the commission reported a year later on the reinforcement projects that enabled connecting new clients that were consuming electricity equivalent to all of Malmö's energy demand. The grid operator, E.ON went to look for customers that could use all this new future capacity while being unable to handle new connections to the grid until the grid was expanded. These reactions expose, in yet another manner, the internal misalignments within the electricity system and the differing dynamics of scaling of cloud computing and energy grids. Electricity grids have to be planned long-term, years ahead, and when customers are not yet in place. Data centres mushroom wherever land is cheap and where providers can find available electricity instead of being driven by the logic of hyperscalable cloud computing. In this misalignment, from being the source of a problem, data centres for AI re-emerge as the solution of the problem by becoming prospective customers who can justify the upscaling of the grid. A report by the Swedish national grid operator, Svenska Kraftnät, suggests that a significant proportion of these new customers will likely be data centres for AI, arguing that the grid must urgently expand to handle more

demand: "The largest requests for connections of data centres amount to 500 MW of capacity from the grid, which is often difficult to realise without reinforcements of the grid" (Svenska Kraftnät, 2019, p. 13), they write, calling for more powerlines across the country.

These frenetic efforts to scale up the electricity grid expose how low carbon hyper-scalable cloud computing is created through the relationships with resources and infrastructures in concrete places with very different logics of scaling. As Anna Tsing writes, scalability efforts are always incomplete, and the inability of an infrastructure to scale exposes the failures of scaling projects (Tsing, 2012, p. 510). Electricity grids in many regions in Sweden simply fail to scale in keeping with the scales at which computing operates. In this case, infrastructural misalignment emerges as a problem of rescaling and of identifying the right scale of entangled infrastructure that would help align the compromised values of economic growth and public access to energy.

Overcoming misalignment between entangled infrastructures demands re-alignments among different values embedded in infrastructure and among different infrastructure logics. The different ways in which these realignments are executed define the premises for whom infrastructures will work, who will they prioritise and exclude, and for how long they will work. They are the core of infrastructure politics and can produce both wealth and violence (Anand et al., 2018; Rodgers & O'Neill, 2012).

In Sweden, contemporary attempts to align electricity grids to the demands of different industries envisions a major nationwide upscaling of the backbone power grid in the country for AI. The upscaling of grids is undoubtedly a lucrative business: it implies more sales for grid operators of very expensive transmission capacity that generates economic gains not just for Big Tech cloud operators but also for the energy industry. In Sweden, a major driver in the upscaling is Svenska Kraftnät, the state-owned authority tasked to plan, maintain, and operate the electricity transmission grid as well as its substations and international connections. The authority develops both the transmission grid and the electricity market in Sweden with the mandate to provide a safe, environmentally sustainable, and economically viable supply of electricity in the country and describes itself as an important actor in Sweden's climate policy (Svenska Kraftnät, 2019).

Until recently, Svenska Kraftnät focused on how to export unused energy production, thereby reinforcing transmission lines within the

country to enable export. Following the crises in transmission capacities in Skåne and a few other regions, the national grid operator issued a 10-year plan for reinforcing and upscaling the grid in Sweden in general (Svenska Kraftnät, 2019). The plan involves major extensions of the grid that involve building new powerlines as well as reinforcing major existing substations and regional transmission infrastructure over the decade. The general motivation, as declared in the 10-year plan that the organisation published, is to respond to the expectations of different actors on the power grid to meet what they call the needs of "societal developments" as well as new needs, while also simultaneously helping Sweden achieve its political and environmental goals within the domain of energy (Svenska Kraftnät, 2019, p. 77). In other words, upscaling the grid is a means of aligning the grid to the appropriate transmission capacities to cover new demand.

The societal developments that the 10-year plan specifies are a combination of increased energy use by urban regions as a result of existing data centre establishments, the shutdown of local electricity production (implied to be the closure of certain nuclear power plants) that has created deficits in transmission and production capacities in many areas, and an anticipated surge in electricity demand from data centres. While there are no public numbers available, Svenska Kraftnät indicates that data centres could request capacities in the range of up to 300 MW–500 MW, which is comparable to the scale of a medium-sized Swedish town (Svenska Kraftnät, 2019, p. 13). The urban areas which face the most capacity deficit are Stockholm, Uppsala, and Malmö and Mälardalen. Except for Uppsala, the other two are places with already a high concentration of data centres or the establishment of Big Tech companies that provide computation resources following the hyper-scalability logic.

It must be noted that data centres are named as just one of four reasons to expand the grid, with the other three being to increase the ability of the grid to connect new wind power plant projects to the grid, to maintain and increase capacity to be able to sell electricity domestically and internationally, and to maintain or replace ageing elements of the power grid (Svenska Kraftnät, 2019). Of these three reasons, wind power is again indirectly related to the expansion of data centres and computation capacities. By their own accounts, a few of the major companies in the business of hyper-scalable cloud computing—Microsoft, Google, Amazon—have all proclaimed themselves as the largest buyers of newly installed renewable power energy. Specifically, in the Nordic countries,

these companies have emerged as important subsidiaries of wind power plant projects, as Big Tech derisks investments in unprofitable wind power projects by committing to buy their electricity for 10–15 years; this makes the production of wind power plants lucrative for investors (Christophers, 2022). As the power grid in Sweden scales up to meet the needs of hyper-scalable computing in its multifarious forms, such as data centres and wind power generation facilities, new problems and misalignments emerge.

One such crucial misalignment is concerned with the divergent temporal horizons of cloud computing and electricity grids. The main sales pitch of hyper-scalable computing is that any computing resource, large or small, can be delivered on demand. Electricity grids can obviously not be rescaled on demand and neither can data centres. The responses to realign electricity grids to the demand of electricity driven by hyper-scalable computing are geared towards achieving greater alignment with the scalability logic of cloud computing. Energy planners do it on their own terms and time horizons. Svenska Kraftnät admits that it takes 10–12 years on average from decision to operation to expand the grid, which is apparently too long a time "when put against the expectations to be able to transition industrial manufacturing from fossil fuels to electricity, build data centres, or new housing" (Svenska Kraftnät, 2019, p. 19).

Their solution is to shorten permission times by managing different processes in parallel, particularly to begin the process of planning for new powerlines before the concession rights to operate the power lines are granted. In this manner, the time taken to install a new powerline might be reduced by 8–10 years, which is still considered too long by grid operators. However, planning for powerlines involves handling conflicts with citizens, such as farmers, indigenous people, potential archaeological sites, cultural and industrial heritage, and environments with their human and non-human inhabitants. Issues of justice and conflicts of values are bound to emerge there as well.

The Swedish Energy Markets Inspectorate (Ei) anticipates working with regions and different agencies, such as the Swedish mapping, cadastral, and land registration authority to shorten the permission processes for expanding the grid. In anticipation of conflicts, administrators in Skåne admit that in their region, this would require dialogue with communities regarding land use and siting as well as work on the aesthetic designs of substations to resolve conflicts with citizens (Skånes effektkommission NET, 2025, p. 13). The large-scale expansion of the grid in Skåne

will also require agricultural land and will claim land from private owners, potentially generating disputes.

As hyper-scalable cloud computing exerts pressure on public values and generates social conflicts around already built infrastructure, upscaling and shortening temporalities of grid planning multiplies the arenas in which societal conflicts might manifest. Upscaling power grids also changes the nature of the conflicts, from disputes over access to electricity to those over land governance issues. Rather than alignments among the values of the hyper-scalability of cloud computing and universal access to electricity, the focus of responses shifts to solving issues around power grid expansion. These responses transform how power grids in Sweden are governed as well. They reduce the temporalities of power grid planning, create new arenas of contestation, and transform the administrative processes that govern these developments.

In the meantime, until power grids scale up, cloud computing infrastructure operators are adapting to longer timelines and plan with longer connections, slowing down expansions of computing infrastructures dedicated to AI systems. This temporal misalignment between the business model for on-demand AI through cloud computing, the production of data centres in anticipation of demand, and the need to search and wait for connections to power grids already generates anxiety in the data centre industries. In other words, while power grid infrastructure operators and municipalities make ten-year plans for infrastructure upscaling and are changing their work practices, the tech industry might have already moved somewhere else in search for more power, creating new misalignments and leaving infrastructure in ruins (see Brodie & Velkova, 2021; Velkova, 2025).

So, What About Sustainability?

The hyper-scalability logic around which cloud computing is currently organised enables digital companies to expand, to experiment with AI model development, and to be extremely successful (Narayan 2022). This success is premised upon pushing entangled infrastructures in misalignment in ways that affect public values. Internal misalignments as well as different spatial and temporal logics of scaling result either in shortages in computing power or in local shortages in electricity that compromise the public value of equal access to energy in Sweden. A close examination of these processes calls for more nuanced discussions on sustainability that

could begin with analyses of infrastructure misalignment and attempts to realign infrastructure, thus focusing on the internal contradictions within and between digital and energy systems as well as how they promote or compromise public values of equal access to basic infrastructure.

Further, the attempts to scale up power grids as a form of alignment to hyper-scalable computing are also fragile and precarious. Power grids have slower and longer temporalities than computing infrastructure, different materialities, professional cultures, markets and regulations. In contrast, the hype around AI today calls for limitless computing here and now, organised around endless scalability. Therefore, even if grids would expand in Sweden over the next decade, as planned, companies in business with AI can easily claim these capacities too, as policymakers attempt to boost the development of computing infrastructure and prioritise it over other sectors. Thus, while cloud computing benefits from the principle of universal access to energy for everyone in Sweden, data centre operators de facto monopolise power grids, crowding out other industries and competitors, including other actors from the data centre industries.

In this context, it is unsurprising to see efforts by resourceful companies—such as Amazon, Microsoft, and Google—to invest in dedicated powerlines and even power plants, thus fending off the pressures on power grids that these very same companies are contributing to create and leading to further monopolisation and misalignments in energy production and grid management.

Importantly, the infrastructural misalignments and responses to them that I have discussed here are not exhaustive or universal by any means. They play out differently in different settings shaped by their histories, people, and industries. In certain places, they might not manifest as conflicts over energy at all but could take shape as conflicts over water infrastructure instead (Lehuedé, 2024; Valdivia, 2024). In this context, a focus on infrastructure misalignments offers a means to reimagine ways of creating aligned futures of entangled data centres and other infrastructures in ways that promote rather than compromise public values. More harmonic alignments might demand a different pace of scaling computing or different ways of organising computing altogether, following not where land is cheap and connectivity best but where there would be the least pressure on local infrastructure, communities, and industries. In other words, we need a different form of computing and varied ethical and

economic models for it; such models must be considerate of the interrelations among data centre industries, which have entangled infrastructures, in ways that protect public values.

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